4.2 The Growth of Slavery

In 2015, author Ta-Nehisi Coates described enslaved Africans as "people turned to fuel for the American machine." The slave labor system that Europeans established in the Americas had an enormous human cost.

MAIN IDEA European access to African slave labor paved the way for the growth of slave labor in the Americas and the expansion of the slave trade.

SLAVERY IN THE AMERICAS

The encomienda and hacienda systems established in Spain's American colonies encouraged the growth of sugar plantations in the West Indies and set the stage for the growth of slavery in North America. These plantations supplied the European market with sugar, and they required a considerable workforce in order to grow and process enough sugarcane to make a profit.

At first, the Spanish forced the islands' Native American populations to work in the sugarcane fields, but ultimately this plan failed. Many Native Americans died of European diseases, while others escaped their bondage.

The inability to force Native Americans into slavery led Spain to turn to Africa as a source of captive labor. At first, the Spanish bought Africans who had been enslaved on the Portuguese plantations. Soon, however, they began buying enslaved Africans directly from West Africa. By the end of the 1500s, 75,000 enslaved Africans were working on Spanish plantations in the Caribbean. The North American slave trade expanded from there.

FAR FROM HOME

Europeans began to buy and ship so many people to the Americas that West African slave hunters had to travel farther into the continent in order to capture and enslave more people to meet the demand. The forced march to the coast was even longer and more brutal, and many people died before they even boarded a ship. Because the slave raiders captured the youngest and most productive members of inland societies, the transatlantic slave trade devastated entire cultures and economies in Africa.

Altogether, the slave trade between Africa and the Americas lasted for about 400 years. From the 16th to the 19th century, traders shipped between 7 and 10 million people to the Western Hemisphere. The removal of so many Africans from their homeland to the Americas is known as the **African diaspora**.

Slavery became an **institution**, or an established and accepted practice, in North America, particularly in the Southern Colonies and then in the new nation, the United States. The international slave trade ended in 1807, and the United States abolished slavery completely in 1865. There is no doubt that slavery as an institution shaped the social, economic, and cultural development of the United States and that it still casts its shadow today.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did the slave trade change as demand for African slaves grew?
2. **MAKE INFERENCES** In what ways did the African diaspora change the population of the African continent?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** How did Portuguese slave trading off the western coast of Africa help contribute to the development of slavery in the Americas?

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The Jamaica Train

When sugar refining first began, enslaved workers used four vats of decreasing size called the Jamaica Train. One of the most dangerous jobs on a sugar plantation was boiling the sugarcane water in vats like the ones shown here. When enough liquid had evaporated from one vat, the water was ladled into the next, smaller, vat. The process occurred two more times with more batches following. Enslaved workers had to move quickly so that all the vats were always full.





Indoor Sugar Refining

This painting by William Clark captures work in a large sugar plantation after technology improved the sugar refining process. Moving this process indoors better regulated the heat. Using brick ovens reduced the number of fires needed to boil the sugarcane, but these advances did not make the work much easier for enslaved workers. They still faced scalding, heat exhaustion, and grueling physical labor.

In 1843, Norbert Rillieux invented an evaporating machine. Additional inventions, such as steam power and a process that lowered the boiling point of liquid, continued to improve the sugar refining process.

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